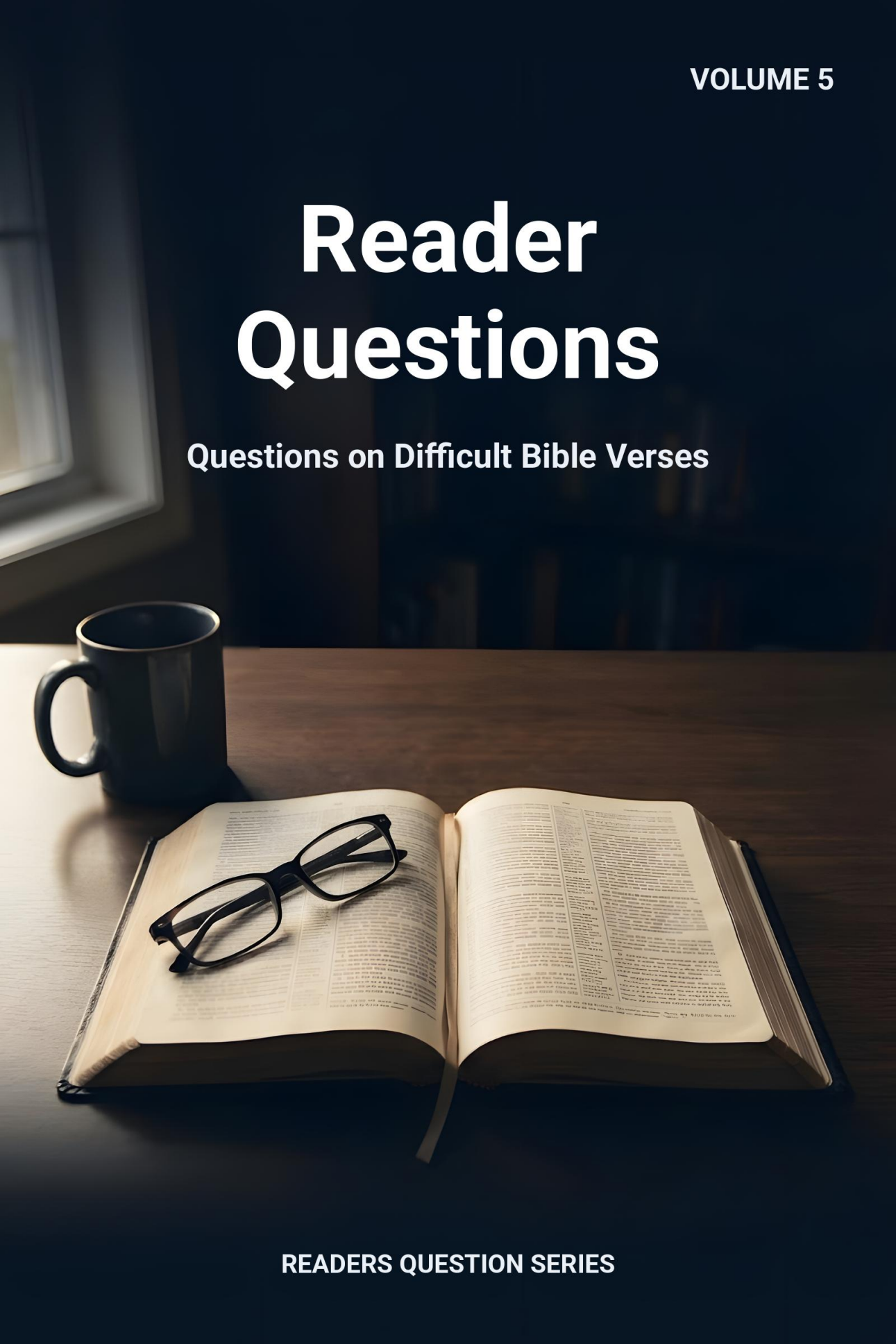
VOLUME 5

Reader Questions

Questions on Difficult Bible Verses



READERS QUESTION SERIES

Reader Questions

Volume 5: Questions on Difficult Bible Verses

HOW TO READ THIS VOLUME

Each entry takes one question a reader has asked about one verse or short passage. It states what the verse means, and then argues that meaning from the verse's own passage and the chapter or chapters before it. The Scripture elsewhere is used as support, not as the foundation. Each entry marks what the text states, what the context shows, and what is inferred, so that the reader can see what carries the weight and judge it. The entries argue a position. Where other readings are held by named writers, they are set beside it with the places where each strains.

Scripture is quoted from the King James Version (KJV). Modern writers are named by author and work; their views are described in the entry's own words, and no quotation marks are used for them.

Contents

1. How Do I Know God's Will? Romans 12:2
2. Why Does God Allow Suffering? Romans 5:3–4
3. How Do I Deal with Doubt? Ephesians 1:13 and 2 Timothy 3:15
4. How Do I Deal with Temptation? 1 Corinthians 10:13
5. How Do I Deal with Unanswered Prayer? 2 Corinthians 12:8–9
6. How Do I Deal with Spiritual Dryness? Colossians 3:16
7. How Do I Deal with Guilt? Colossians 2:13–14
8. How Do I Deal with Fear? 2 Timothy 1:7
9. What Is the Fate of Infants Who Die? 2 Samuel 12:23
10. What Is the Conscience? Romans 2:15

1. How Do I Know God's Will? Romans 12:2

THE ANSWER

The Body of Christ knows God's will through Paul's revelation, not through signs, dreams or prophetic guidance. Paul says the way is a renewed mind: "be ye transformed by the renewing of your mind, that ye may prove what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect, will of God." The will he then names is stated in his letters: sanctification, thanksgiving, and being "filled with the knowledge of his will in all wisdom and spiritual understanding." The Spirit guides by opening what has been revealed, not by outward signs. The methods of Israel's prophetic setting, such as casting lots and waiting for a voice, are not set before the Body. Wisdom comes by applying Paul's doctrine with prayer, and the aim of the will is "Christ be formed in you."

Where the Verses Stand

Romans 12 turns from doctrine to the believer's walk. Paul beseeches "brethren" to present their bodies, tells them not to be conformed to the world, and says the alternative is a renewed mind that proves God's will. He goes on to the gifts, love and conduct that follow. The other passages Paul uses on the will of God are brief and direct: sanctification and thanksgiving in 1 Thessalonians, the knowledge of his will in Colossians, and Scripture's power to equip in 2 Timothy.

Israel's line knew other ways. The Twelve gave forth lots in Acts 1:26, before the Spirit came, and the proverb says "The lot is cast into the lap; but the whole disposing thereof is of the LORD" (Proverbs 16:33). Those belong to Israel's prophetic setting. A hard case sits in Acts 9–28: Paul is "forbidden of the Holy Ghost to preach the word in Asia" and a vision appears to him in the night (Acts 16:6–10). These are recorded in settings shaped by Israel's Prophecy Program, which remained operative throughout Acts 9–28 even as the Mystery Program began. Acts 9–28 is the overlap; where Paul is the one guided, this entry reports the text and does not make the event a method for the Body, since his letters to the Body never set signs or visions before the believer as the way to know God's will.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Rom 12:2	"And be not conformed to this world: but be ye transformed by the renewing of your mind, that ye may prove what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect, will of God."	Transformed by the renewing of the mind; the will of God is proved.
1 Th 4:3	"For this is the will of God, even your sanctification, that ye should abstain from fornication:"	The will of God: your sanctification.
1 Th 5:18	"In every thing give thanks: for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus concerning you."	Thanks in everything is "the will of God in Christ Jesus concerning you."
Col 1:9	"For this cause we also, since the day we heard it, do not cease to pray for you, and to desire that ye might be filled with the knowledge of his will in all wisdom and spiritual understanding;"	Filled with the knowledge of his will.

Acts 1:26	“And they gave forth their lots; and the lot fell upon Matthias; and he was numbered with the eleven apostles.”	The Twelve give forth lots (Acts 1–8).

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Romans 12:2 gives the method: not conformed to the world but transformed by the renewing of the mind, “that ye may prove” what God’s will is. The will is proved by a renewed mind, not delivered by a sign.
- **Stated:** Paul names parts of the will outright: “your sanctification” (1 Thessalonians 4:3) and thanks “in every thing” (5:18), and he prays that the Colossians be “filled with the knowledge of his will in all wisdom and spiritual understanding” (Colossians 1:9).
- **Shown by the context:** the means Paul points to is the written word: “All scripture is given by inspiration of God … That the man of God may be perfect, throughly furnished unto all good works” (2 Timothy 3:16–17). The Spirit’s part is knowing “the things that are freely given to us of God” (1 Corinthians 2:12), which concerns what God has given, not a private direction.
- **Shown by the context:** the lot is the method of the Twelve in Acts 1:26, within Acts 1–8, and Hebrews 1:1–2 says God spoke “in time past unto the fathers by the prophets” and “in these last days” by his Son. These belong to Israel’s prophetic line, and Paul’s letters to the Body never instruct a believer to cast lots or wait for a voice.
- **Shown by the context:** the Spirit’s part in knowing the will is stated as knowledge of what God has given: “we have received, not the spirit of the world, but the spirit which is of God; that we might know the things that are freely given to us of God” (1 Corinthians 2:12). The Spirit opens what is already given and does not add a private word beside it.
- **Inferred:** that where Scripture gives no command, the Body decides by wisdom applying Paul’s doctrine, with prayer (Philippians 4:6–7). The argument rests on 12:2, on Colossians 1:9 and on Paul’s silence about signs as guidance for the Body.

The Other Readings

Specific personal guidance. Henry Blackaby (*Experiencing God*) teaches that God speaks to the individual through Scripture, prayer, circumstances and the church, and that the believer’s task is to find where God is at work and join him. It must explain why Paul’s letters never promise this and why they put the will in a renewed mind.
Wisdom within God’s revealed will. Garry Friesen (*Decision Making and the Will of God*) and Bruce Waltke (*Finding the Will of God: A Pagan Notion?*) argue that Scripture gives God’s moral will and that open decisions are made by wisdom, with no hidden individual plan to discover. That is close to the reading taken here, with the added point that the Body’s will is Paul’s revelation and Israel’s methods are a different program’s.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Specific personal guidance	God directs each step through inner leading and circumstances.	Paul never promises it; Romans 12:2 puts the will in a renewed mind.
Wisdom within the revealed will	Obey what Scripture commands; decide the rest by wisdom.	It must show the will is Paul's revelation, not a general ethic.
Israel's methods for the Body	Lots, signs and prophetic voices guide the believer.	They belong to Acts 1–8 and Israel's line; Paul does not give them to the Body.

What It Means for the Reader

The reader is asked to read Paul, let the mind be renewed, give thanks, pursue holiness and pray, and to expect God's will to be known that way. The goal of the will is stated: Christ "be formed in you" (Galatians 4:19). Waiting for a sign before obeying what is already written puts the order the wrong way round. The passage does not say that every choice has a single hidden right answer, and it does not promise that obedience will be felt as certainty. It names what God wills and the way the mind is changed, and it leaves the rest to wisdom, prayer and the counsel of other believers.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 45, Sanctification Under Grace, reports what Scripture says of the believer's sanctifying. **Companions:** Romans; 1 Thessalonians.

2. Why Does God Allow Suffering? Romans 5:3–4

THE ANSWER

For the Body, suffering is not covenant punishment, because the Body is not under the Law. Paul says "tribulation worketh patience; And patience, experience; and experience, hope," and that to believe is also "to suffer for his sake." God uses suffering to show Christ's strength in weakness: "my strength is made perfect in weakness." The Body is not promised earthly deliverance; "all that will live godly in Christ Jesus shall suffer persecution." Suffering loosens the hold of the world and fixes the mind on things above, and God works it with everything else "for good to them that love God." The "light affliction" of the present "worketh for us a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory." This is the Body's word on suffering; it is not Israel's, whose remnant is promised deliverance in the kingdom.

Where the Verses Stand

Romans 5 begins with peace with God by faith and standing in grace, and Paul adds that believers "glory in tribulations also." The reason follows in the next two verses. Paul's other words on suffering are written from his own affliction: the thorn and the answer to it (2 Corinthians 12), the light affliction (2 Corinthians 4), the gift of suffering (Philippians 1:29) and the warning to Timothy (2 Timothy 3:12).

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Rom 5:3–4	"And not only so, but we glory in tribulations also: knowing that tribulation worketh patience; And patience, experience; and experience, hope:"	Tribulation, patience, experience, hope.
2 Co 12:9	"And he said unto me, My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness. Most gladly therefore will I rather glory in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me."	"My strength is made perfect in weakness."
Phil 1:29	"For unto you it is given in the behalf of Christ, not only to believe on him, but also to suffer for his sake;"	Given "not only to believe on him, but also to suffer for his sake."
2 Ti 3:12	"Yea, and all that will live godly in Christ Jesus shall suffer persecution."	"All that will live godly … shall suffer persecution."

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Paul gives suffering a purpose in the believer: it works patience, experience and hope (Romans 5:3–4), and its weight is outweighed by glory (2 Corinthians 4:17).
- **Stated:** the Lord's own answer to Paul's prayer was "My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness" (2 Corinthians 12:9), not removal of the thorn.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul says the Body is not under the Law: "ye are not under the law, but under grace" (Romans 6:14). Suffering therefore is not read as a covenant curse, as it is in Israel's covenant where blessing and cursing follow obedience.
- **Shown by the context:** suffering is spoken of as a gift and a calling in this age: "it is given in the behalf of Christ, not only to believe on him, but also to suffer for his

sake" (Philippians 1:29), and Paul tells Timothy that persecution accompanies godliness (2 Timothy 3:12). No earthly deliverance is promised.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul's own sufferings are listed to the Corinthians, and he calls the present "light affliction, which is but for a moment" (2 Corinthians 4:17). He does not say the sufferings are small; he sets them against the weight of glory to come.
- **Inferred:** that God's allowing suffering serves these ends and that the Body's future service is part of them. Paul says "all things work together for good to them that love God" (Romans 8:28) and that affliction "worketh for us a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory" (2 Corinthians 4:17); the argument rests on those statements and does not claim to explain every particular suffering.

The Other Readings

God's purposes in suffering, with a mystery left. D. A. Carson (*How Long, O Lord? Reflections on Suffering and Evil*) and Tim Keller (*Walking with God through Pain and Suffering*) hold that God is sovereign over suffering and uses it for good ends while much stays hidden. This is close to the reading taken here, with the Body's particular word added. **A God who risks and does not control.** Gregory Boyd (*Satan and the Problem of Evil*) argues that much suffering is the work of hostile powers and that God does not will each event. It must explain why Paul tells believers their suffering has a purpose in God's hand.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
God's purposes, with mystery	God is sovereign over suffering and uses it for the believer's good.	It must not claim to explain each case; Paul does not.
God does not will each event	Hostile powers cause much suffering; God works against them.	Paul says all things work together for good to those who love God.
Suffering as covenant discipline	Hardship answers disobedience, as in Israel's covenant.	The Body is not under the Law; Romans 6:14.

What It Means for the Reader

The verse does not explain why a particular loss happened, and Paul does not try to. It tells the reader what God does with suffering in the Body: it produces patience and hope, it displays Christ's strength, it fixes the mind on things above and it is not a punishment under the Law. The reader is not told to expect the removal of the affliction in this age. The passage does not say that suffering is good in itself, that every sufferer deserves comfort in the same measure or that the reasons will be known in this life. It says what God does with affliction and what the believer's response should be, and it leaves the particular case with God.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 59, The Law's Jurisdiction and the Body of Christ, reports where the Law's authority stands. **Companions:** Romans; 2 Corinthians.

3. How Do I Deal with Doubt? Ephesians 1:13 and 2 Timothy 3:15

THE ANSWER

Doubt is met by returning to what Paul wrote, which steadies the mind, and the Body is not asked to look for signs to confirm it. Believers were "sealed with that holy Spirit of promise" when they believed, so doubt is not a sign of lost salvation. The Spirit helps by opening what God has given, "that we might know the things that are freely given to us of God." The Lord's refusal of a sign to Israel ("An evil and adulterous generation seeketh after a sign") shows that asking for confirmations belongs to Israel's setting. Doubt weakens as Scripture is read and believed, and Paul tells believers to "stand fast in the faith," to pray with thanksgiving and to handle the word of truth rightly. Faith grows by hearing.

Where the Verses Stand

Ephesians 1 speaks to saints and faithful in Christ Jesus and says that after they heard "the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation," and believed, they were sealed with the Holy Spirit. Paul's other words on faith are to Timothy, who learned the Scriptures from a child, and to the Corinthians, whom he tells to stand fast. The Lord's word on signs is spoken to Israel in Matthew 12.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Eph 1:13	"In whom ye also trusted, after that ye heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation: in whom also after that ye believed, ye were sealed with that holy Spirit of promise,"	Heard, believed, "sealed with that holy Spirit of promise."
1 Co 2:12	"Now we have received, not the spirit of the world, but the spirit which is of God; that we might know the things that are freely given to us of God."	The Spirit that we might know what is given to us of God.
Mt 12:39	"But he answered and said unto them, An evil and adulterous generation seeketh after a sign; and there shall no sign be given to it, but the sign of the prophet Jonas:"	"An evil and adulterous generation seeketh after a sign."
1 Co 16:13	"Watch ye, stand fast in the faith, quit you like men, be strong."	"Watch ye, stand fast in the faith."
2 Ti 3:15	"And that from a child thou hast known the holy scriptures, which are able to make thee wise unto salvation through faith which is in Christ Jesus."	The holy scriptures "able to make thee wise unto salvation."

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the Body is sealed on believing: "after that ye believed, ye were sealed with that holy Spirit of promise" (Ephesians 1:13). The seal is not removed by doubt.
- **Stated:** Paul's remedy for a troubled heart is prayer with thanksgiving, with the result that "the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your

hearts and minds" (Philippians 4:6–7), and the instruction to "stand fast in the faith" (1 Corinthians 16:13).

- **Shown by the context:** the Lord's refusal of a sign to Israel (Matthew 12:39) is spoken to Israel's scribes and Pharisees; signs as confirmation belong to Israel's setting ("the Jews require a sign," 1 Corinthians 1:22). The Body's footing is the revealed word.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul tells Timothy that the scriptures are "able to make thee wise unto salvation through faith which is in Christ Jesus" (2 Timothy 3:15) and tells him to be "rightly dividing the word of truth" (2 Timothy 2:15). Faith is nourished by the word. Romans 10:17 states that faith comes by hearing, in the chapter addressed to Israel; the principle is used here only as a general truth and carries no weight for the argument.
- **Shown by the context:** Timothy is reminded that "from a child thou hast known the holy scriptures" (2 Timothy 3:15). The steady mind he has been given comes from what he has long read and believed, not from a recent sign.
- **Inferred:** that doubt is a lapse in the believer's grip on what is true and not a loss of standing. The text says the believer is sealed and tells him to stand fast; the argument rests on those two statements.

The Other Readings

Doubt as a path to deeper faith. Some writers treat doubt as something to be faced honestly, distinguishing doubts of faith from doubts of unbelief. This fits the reading taken here where doubt is met by returning to the truth. **Doubt answered by evidence.** Gary Habermas (*Dealing with Doubt*) gives factual, emotional and volitional answers, and stresses the evidence for the resurrection. The reading taken here agrees that the word steadies the mind but does not rest the Body's assurance on signs.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Doubt is honestly faced	Name the doubt and bring it to the truth.	Paul's remedy is the word and prayer, not self-examination alone.
Doubt answered by evidence	Reasoned grounds settle the mind.	Paul puts the Body's assurance in the seal and the word, not in signs.
Doubt as lost salvation	Persistent doubt means no standing.	The Body is sealed on believing; Ephesians 1:13.

What It Means for the Reader

The reader who doubts is sent back to what is written, told that he is sealed, asked to pray with thanksgiving and to stand fast. Waiting for a sign is the way Israel was rebuked for seeking, and is not the Body's way. The passage does not say the believer will never doubt, and it does not treat a doubting believer as an unbeliever. It speaks of a seal and a word, and it asks the reader to keep hold of both when his feelings and his questions press hard.

Related Reading

Companions: Ephesians; 1 Corinthians.

4. How Do I Deal with Temptation? 1 Corinthians 10:13

THE ANSWER

Temptation is resisted by walking in the Spirit. The Body is not under the Law, so victory does not come through legalism. Paul tells believers to "reckon ye also yourselves to be dead indeed unto sin, but alive unto God," and promises that God "will with the temptation also make a way to escape." Renewing the mind with Paul's doctrine weakens temptation's hold, the Spirit's fruit includes "temperance," and Timothy is told to "flee also youthful lusts." Victory is rooted in who the believer is in Christ, not in willpower: "ye are dead, and your life is hid with Christ in God."

Where the Verses Stand

Paul writes to Corinth after the wilderness examples of Israel's failure and tells them, "Let him that thinketh he standeth take heed lest he fall." The verse that follows is the promise. His other words on temptation are in Romans 6 (reckoning), Galatians 5 (the Spirit and the flesh), 2 Timothy 2 (flee) and Colossians 3 (the life hid with Christ).

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
1 Co 10:13	"There hath no temptation taken you but such as is common to man: but God is faithful, who will not suffer you to be tempted above that ye are able; but will with the temptation also make a way to escape, that ye may be able to bear it."	No temptation but common; God is faithful; a way to escape.
Gal 5:16	"This I say then, Walk in the Spirit, and ye shall not fulfil the lust of the flesh."	"Walk in the Spirit, and ye shall not fulfil the lust of the flesh."
Rom 6:11	"Likewise reckon ye also yourselves to be dead indeed unto sin, but alive unto God through Jesus Christ our Lord."	Reckon yourselves dead unto sin, alive unto God.
Col 3:3	"For ye are dead, and your life is hid with Christ in God."	"Your life is hid with Christ in God."

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Paul's promise is that God "will not suffer you to be tempted above that ye are able; but will with the temptation also make a way to escape, that ye may be able to bear it" (1 Corinthians 10:13).
- **Stated:** the means is the Spirit: "Walk in the Spirit, and ye shall not fulfil the lust of the flesh" (Galatians 5:16), and the Spirit's fruit includes "temperance" (Galatians 5:23).
- **Shown by the context:** the basis is a reckoning, not a rule: "Likewise reckon ye also yourselves to be dead indeed unto sin, but alive unto God" (Romans 6:11), after the word that "sin shall not have dominion over you: for ye are not under the law, but under grace" (Romans 6:14).
- **Shown by the context:** Paul also commands flight: "Flee also youthful lusts" (2 Timothy 2:22), and grounds the whole in identity: "For ye are dead, and your life is hid with Christ in God" (Colossians 3:3).
- **Shown by the context:** the verse that precedes the promise warns the confident: "Wherefore let him that thinketh he standeth take heed lest he fall" (1 Corinthians

10:12). The promise of a way out is given to those who take temptation seriously.
- **Inferred:** that victory is chiefly a matter of identity renewed by Paul's doctrine and carried out by the Spirit, and not by effort. The passages say all three things; the order is the argument's.

The Other Readings

Victory by surrender. The Keswick teaching holds that the believer finds victory by yielding to Christ and not striving. It is close to the reading taken here but must show that the believer's own reckoning and flight are also commanded. **Victory by discipline.** Teachers of the spiritual disciplines hold that habits of Scripture, prayer and fellowship train the believer against sin. The reading taken here agrees that the mind must be renewed but sets the ground in the believer's standing, not in practice alone.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Surrender	Yield to Christ and he overcomes in you.	Paul also commands reckoning and flight.
Discipline	Habits of Scripture, prayer and fellowship train the believer.	Paul's ground is standing in Christ, not practice alone.
Law as the check	Rules and prohibitions restrain the flesh.	Romans 6:14: not under the law, but under grace.

What It Means for the Reader

The reader is told that no temptation is beyond what can be borne, that God provides the way out, that he is dead to sin and alive to God, and that he is to walk in the Spirit and flee. A rule list is not what Paul hands the Body. The passage does not say a believer will never fall, and it does not offer a rule list. It speaks of standing, of the Spirit and of flight, and it leaves the believer who has failed to the forgiveness Paul describes elsewhere.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 59, The Law's Jurisdiction and the Body of Christ.
Companions: Romans; Galatians.

5. How Do I Deal with Unanswered Prayer? 2 Corinthians 12:8–9

THE ANSWER

Unanswered prayer is not a covenant judgment on the Body, which is not under the Law and not Israel. God answers according to his wisdom, and Paul's own case shows what that can mean: he besought the Lord three times that the thorn "might depart from me," and the answer was "My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness." Some requests are not granted because they cut across God's purposes for the believer's growth, and "all things work together for good to them that love God." The Spirit helps in prayer according to the will of God and not ours. Believers are told to give thanks in everything, to continue in prayer, and to rest in the character of the God they know: "I know whom I have believed."

Where the Verses Stand

In 2 Corinthians 12 Paul describes the thorn in the flesh and says he asked for its removal three times. The answer follows at once, with his conclusion about weakness. His other words on prayer are Philippians 4 (prayer with thanksgiving), Romans 8 (the Spirit's help), Colossians 4 (continue in prayer) and 2 Timothy 1 (the confidence of one who knows whom he has believed).

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
2 Co 12:8	"For this thing I besought the Lord thrice, that it might depart from me."	"I besought the Lord thrice, that it might depart from me."
2 Co 12:9	"And he said unto me, My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness. Most gladly therefore will I rather glory in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me."	"My grace is sufficient for thee."
Rom 8:26	"Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought: but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered."	The Spirit helps our infirmities in prayer.
Col 4:2	"Continue in prayer, and watch in the same with thanksgiving;"	"Continue in prayer … with thanksgiving."
2 Ti 1:12	"For the which cause I also suffer these things: nevertheless I am not ashamed: for I know whom I have believed, and am persuaded that he is able to keep that which I have committed unto him against that day."	"I know whom I have believed."

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Paul prayed three times for relief and was told the grace was sufficient and the weakness would carry Christ's power (2 Corinthians 12:8–9). His prayer was heard and the answer was not removal.

- **Stated:** the Spirit "helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought," and intercedes "according to the will of God" (Romans 8:26–27).
- **Shown by the context:** Paul does not treat the unanswered request as a failure of faith or a judgment; he accepts it and boasts in his infirmities (2 Corinthians 12:9–10). The Body is told "ye are not under the law, but under grace" (Romans 6:14), so a withheld answer is not a covenant curse.
- **Shown by the context:** the instructions that follow unanswered prayer in Paul are thanksgiving (1 Thessalonians 5:18) and perseverance: "Continue in prayer, and watch in the same with thanksgiving" (Colossians 4:2).
- **Shown by the context:** Paul draws a lesson from the refusal: "Most gladly therefore will I rather glory in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me" (2 Corinthians 12:9). He does not demand a reason; he accepts the answer and finds in it what the Lord intended.
- **Inferred:** that a withheld request can serve a purpose the believer cannot yet see, and that the proper answer is trust in God's character. Paul's case and Romans 8:28 support it; no passage promises that every request will be granted.

The Other Readings

Pray with faith and God will give. The word-of-faith teaching, as in Kenneth Copeland (*The Laws of Prosperity*), holds that confident, specific prayer secures what is asked. It must explain why Paul's own prayer was refused and why his answer was grace. **God answers in his way.** D. A. Carson (*A Call to Spiritual Reformation*) and Philip Yancey (*Prayer: Does It Make Any Difference?*) write of prayer as a relationship in which God does not always give what is asked. The reading taken here agrees and rests the point on Paul's own case and on the Body's standing under grace.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Faith secures the request	Confident prayer gets what it names.	Paul's three prayers were refused; 2 Corinthians 12:9.
God answers in his way	The request may be refused for the believer's good.	It must not make the refusal a punishment.
Unanswered prayer as covenant discipline	Silence signals failure under the covenant.	The Body is not under the Law; Romans 6:14.

What It Means for the Reader

The reader is not told that unanswered prayer means he has failed or that God has turned from him. He is told what Paul was told: grace is sufficient. He is to keep praying, give thanks and trust a God whose character he knows. The passage does not promise that every request will be granted, and it does not say how long a request may go unanswered. It records one man's prayer, the Lord's answer and the apostle's response, and it asks the reader to bring his own requests in the same way.

Related Reading

Companions: 2 Corinthians; Romans.

6. How Do I Deal with Spiritual Dryness? Colossians 3:16

THE ANSWER

Dryness often comes from neglecting Scripture, prayer or fellowship, and renewal comes through Paul's doctrine opened by the Spirit. The Body is not told to seek revival through signs or emotional experience: "we walk by faith, not by sight." The word is the remedy: "Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly." Prayer turns the heart toward God, and fellowship with mature believers strengthens faith, as Paul wrote to Rome, that "I may be comforted together with you by the mutual faith both of you and me." Dry seasons end when the believer keeps at the truth and the discipline: "let us not be weary in well doing: for in due season we shall reap." God uses them to teach dependence, as Paul learned in affliction.

Where the Verses Stand

Colossians 3 sets the believer's mind on things above and then says how the word is to live in the assembly: teaching and admonishing one another and singing to the Lord. Paul's other words are on the Spirit's teaching in 1 Corinthians 2, walking by faith in 2 Corinthians 5, endurance in Galatians 6 and mutual comfort in Romans 1.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Col 3:16	"Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly in all wisdom; teaching and admonishing one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing with grace in your hearts to the Lord."	The word of Christ dwells richly; teaching, admonishing, singing.
1 Co 2:13	"Which things also we speak, not in the words which man's wisdom teacheth, but which the Holy Ghost teacheth; comparing spiritual things with spiritual."	The Holy Ghost teaches; spiritual things with spiritual.
2 Co 5:7	"(For we walk by faith, not by sight:)"	"We walk by faith, not by sight."
Gal 6:9	"And let us not be weary in well doing: for in due season we shall reap, if we faint not."	Not weary in well doing; in due season we shall reap.
Rom 1:12	"That is, that I may be comforted together with you by the mutual faith both of you and me."	Comforted together by the mutual faith.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Paul's command: "Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly in all wisdom; teaching and admonishing one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs" (Colossians 3:16). The word is to be taken in and shared.
- **Stated:** Paul says faith is walked, not felt: "we walk by faith, not by sight" (2 Corinthians 5:7); feeling is not made the measure.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul tells the Corinthians that the Spirit teaches by "comparing spiritual things with spiritual" (1 Corinthians 2:13), which is the renewing of the mind by Scripture. Hebrews 10:25, written to Hebrew believers,

speaks of not forsaking "the assembling of ourselves together," a point Paul makes in his own words in Romans 1:12 and Colossians 3:16.

- **Shown by the context:** Paul's own seasons of weakness drove him to God: "we had the sentence of death in ourselves, that we should not trust in ourselves, but in God which raiseth the dead" (2 Corinthians 1:9).
- **Shown by the context:** Paul tells the Galatians that weariness is real: "let us not be weary in well doing" (Galatians 6:9). He assumes believers will tire and speaks to the tiredness, not to a defect of faith.
- **Inferred:** that dryness commonly follows neglect and is cured by returning to the word, prayer and fellowship. Paul gives the remedies; he does not diagnose every dry season as neglect, and the argument does not claim he does.

The Other Readings

Disciplines renew the believer. Teachers of the spiritual disciplines call the believer to Scripture, prayer, fellowship and other practices. This is close to the reading taken here, with the added point that Paul's doctrine is the content. **The dark night.** Gerald May (*The Dark Night of the Soul*) describes seasons when God seems absent as part of a deepening of faith. It must explain why Paul gives the Body practical remedies and not a path through absence.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Disciplines	Scripture, prayer and fellowship restore.	The content must be Paul's doctrine, not practice alone.
The dark night	Absence of felt closeness is part of growth.	Paul gives remedies and does not treat dryness as a stage.
Seek revival by signs	Experience renews the believer.	2 Corinthians 5:7: faith, not sight.

What It Means for the Reader

The reader in a dry season is sent back to the word, to prayer and to other believers, and is told not to measure faith by feeling. Seasons pass when the truth is kept and the work continued. The passage does not say that a dry season is always the believer's fault, or that it will end by a set day. It gives the word, prayer and the assembly as the means, and it leaves the timing to God.

Related Reading

Companions: Colossians; 2 Corinthians.

7. How Do I Deal with Guilt? Colossians 2:13–14

THE ANSWER

Guilt is dealt with by believing that the Body is fully forgiven in Christ. Paul says God has "forgiven you all trespasses" and the "handwriting of ordinances that was against us" is gone. "Therefore being justified by faith, we have peace with God." Confession acknowledges the sin, but cleansing rests on Christ's finished work: "we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins." Lasting guilt often comes from not understanding grace, as when the Galatians began in the Spirit and fell back on the flesh. The Spirit assures the believer of his standing: "The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God." Guilt should lead to a change of mind, not despair, and truth, not emotion, defeats it.

Where the Verses Stand

Colossians 2 says that the Body, once dead in sins, has been made alive with Christ and forgiven all trespasses, with the record against it cancelled at the cross. Paul's other words are Romans 5 (peace by justification), Ephesians 1 (redemption), Galatians 3 (grace not the flesh), Romans 8 (the Spirit's witness), 2 Corinthians 7 (godly sorrow) and Philippians 4 (what to think on).

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Col 2:13	"And you, being dead in your sins and the uncircumcision of your flesh, hath he quickened together with him, having forgiven you all trespasses;"	"Having forgiven you all trespasses."
Col 2:14	"Blotting out the handwriting of ordinances that was against us, which was contrary to us, and took it out of the way, nailing it to his cross;"	The handwriting of ordinances blotted out; nailed to his cross.
Rom 5:1	"Therefore being justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ:"	Justified by faith, peace with God.
Eph 1:7	"In whom we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, according to the riches of his grace;"	Redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins.
2 Co 7:10	"For godly sorrow worketh repentance to salvation not to be repented of: but the sorrow of the world worketh death."	Godly sorrow worketh repentance.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Paul says the forgiveness is already complete: "having forgiven you all trespasses" (Colossians 2:13), with the record "nailing it to his cross" (2:14). The believer's peace is "being justified by faith" (Romans 5:1).
- **Stated:** Paul writes that the Body has "redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, according to the riches of his grace" (Ephesians 1:7), and the Spirit "beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God" (Romans 8:16).
- **Shown by the context:** Paul rebukes the Galatians for starting in the Spirit and being "made perfect by the flesh" (Galatians 3:3), which shows that lasting guilt after faith is a sign of looking to one's own performance.

- **Shown by the context:** Paul distinguishes “godly sorrow” that “worketh repentance to salvation not to be repented of” from “the sorrow of the world” that “worketh death” (2 Corinthians 7:10). The repentance in view is a change of mind in believers who had sinned, not a condition of the forgiveness already given.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul says the old charge was against “us” and was taken “out of the way, nailing it to his cross” (Colossians 2:14). The accuser has no standing document left to produce.
- **Inferred:** that persistent guilt in a believer is chiefly a failure to believe what has been given. The passages say the forgiveness is complete and that sorrow should lead to a change of mind; the argument joins the two.

The Other Readings

Confession restores fellowship. A common teaching is that the believer’s eternal forgiveness is settled and that confession restores fellowship. This fits the reading taken here and must show that Paul speaks to guilt by pointing to the finished forgiveness. **Guilt and shame.** Edward Welch (*Shame Interrupted*) distinguishes guilt from shame and treats both through the gospel’s cleansing and acceptance. The reading taken here agrees that the answer is what God has done.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Fellowship restored by confession	Forgiveness is eternal; confession restores fellowship.	Paul’s texts address the settled forgiveness.
Guilt and shame addressed by the gospel	The gospel cleanses and accepts.	It must not leave the believer to feel his way.
Ongoing forgiveness depends on confession	Unconfessed sin leaves guilt standing.	Colossians 2:13 says all trespasses are forgiven.

What It Means for the Reader

The reader is told to believe what is written: forgiven all trespasses, justified, at peace, a child with the Spirit’s witness. When conscience accuses, the answer is what Christ did, not a fresh effort to feel forgiven. The passage does not say that sin no longer matters, and it does not forbid sorrow over it. It says the debt is paid and the record cancelled, and it asks that the believer’s sorrow be of the kind that turns toward God and not toward despair.

Related Reading

Companions: Colossians; Romans.

8. How Do I Deal with Fear? 2 Timothy 1:7

THE ANSWER

Fear is met by grounding the heart in what God has given the Body. Paul says "God hath not given us the spirit of fear; but of power, and of love, and of a sound mind," and that believers have not received "the spirit of bondage again to fear." The Body is not appointed to wrath: "God hath not appointed us to wrath, but to obtain salvation." God's peace "shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus" when truth is believed, and the Spirit strengthens courage as the mind is renewed. Meditation on Scripture and fellowship with other believers steady the heart. Fear is a call to deeper trust, as David wrote: "What time I am afraid, I will trust in thee," a general truth that Paul's teaching confirms.

Where the Verses Stand

Paul writes 2 Timothy from prison, near the end, and tells Timothy to stir up the gift of God and not to be timid. Romans 8 describes the Spirit of adoption who casts out the spirit of bondage. Philippians 4 gives the peace that keeps the heart. Psalm 56 is David's word in a time of fear.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
2 Ti 1:7	"For God hath not given us the spirit of fear; but of power, and of love, and of a sound mind."	"God hath not given us the spirit of fear."
Rom 8:15	"For ye have not received the spirit of bondage again to fear; but ye have received the Spirit of adoption, whereby we cry, Abba, Father."	Not the spirit of bondage again to fear, but adoption.
1 Th 5:9	"For God hath not appointed us to wrath, but to obtain salvation by our Lord Jesus Christ,"	"God hath not appointed us to wrath."
Phil 4:7	"And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus."	The peace of God keeps hearts and minds.
Ps 56:3	"What time I am afraid, I will trust in thee."	"What time I am afraid, I will trust in thee."

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** God "hath not given us the spirit of fear; but of power, and of love, and of a sound mind" (2 Timothy 1:7), and believers have received "the Spirit of adoption, whereby we cry, Abba, Father" (Romans 8:15).
- **Stated:** Paul says the Body's destiny is not wrath: "God hath not appointed us to wrath, but to obtain salvation by our Lord Jesus Christ" (1 Thessalonians 5:9).
- **Shown by the context:** the means is the mind and the peace of God: "the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus" (Philippians 4:7), and "to be spiritually minded is life and peace" (Romans 8:6).
- **Shown by the context:** Psalm 56:3 is David's word in a time of fear, and the believer today may take it as a general truth of trusting God; it is cited here as a principle and not as the Body's instruction. Hebrews 10:24 and Paul's words in Colossians 3:16 encourage mutual stirring-up.

- **Shown by the context:** Timothy is told in the same chapter not to be "ashamed of the testimony of our Lord" (2 Timothy 1:8). Paul addresses a man who is afraid and does not rebuke him as unbelieving; he reminds him of what God has given.
- **Inferred:** that fear is addressed chiefly by believing what God has given and removed, and not by rebuking a spirit. The texts name the gift and the removal; the argument infers the method.

The Other Readings

Fear as a spirit to cast out. Frank Hammond (*Pigs in the Parlor*) teaches that fear can be a demonic spirit to be rebuked. It must explain why Paul tells Timothy what God has given and not a ritual. **Fear and the God of rest.** Some treat fear as a call to know God's character and to take refuge in him. This is close to the reading taken here.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
A spirit to cast out	Rebuke or deliverance removes fear.	Paul says what God has given, and does not command a rebuke.
Fear met by knowing God	Know his character and take refuge.	The Body's ground is what Paul says he has given.
Fear as unbelief only	Fear shows the believer has failed.	Paul treats Timothy's timidity with encouragement.

What It Means for the Reader

The reader is told that fear is not what God gave, that the Spirit gives power, love and a sound mind, that the Body is not appointed to wrath, and that peace keeps the heart. Fear then becomes the signal to remember these and trust. The passage does not say a believer will never be afraid, and it does not call every fear sin. Timothy is encouraged, not scolded, and the reader is given reasons to trust and the peace that follows.

Related Reading

Companions: 2 Timothy; Romans.

9. What Is the Fate of Infants Who Die? 2 Samuel 12:23

THE ANSWER

Infants who die are safe with God. They have not reached the understanding by which a person is held accountable, so the Law does not condemn them, conscience has not charged them and they have not rejected a gospel. David's word over his dead child, "I shall go to him, but he shall not return to me," shows that God receives one who had no moral capacity. God's justice and mercy guarantee it: "Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right?" The Body is not formed by death, because Body membership is by believing Paul's gospel and being sealed, which an infant has not done. The infant's end follows God's righteousness and not speculation, and his character, "merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and plenteous in mercy," stands behind the confidence. Their fate is mercy, not judgment.

Where the Verses Stand

David's child by Bathsheba was struck by the Lord and died after seven days. While the child lived David fasted and wept, and when he learned of the death he rose, washed and ate. His servants asked why, and he answered with the reasons in verse 22 and verse 23. Other passages bear on the question: Paul's statement that where no law is there is no transgression (Romans 4:15), his account of the conscience and the law written in the heart (Romans 2), Abraham's question to the Judge of all the earth (Genesis 18) and the Body's sealing at faith (Ephesians 1:13).

Other passages are often brought to the question, and each speaks in its own setting. The Lord says "Suffer little children, and forbid them not, to come unto me: for of such is the kingdom of heaven" (Matthew 19:14), in his ministry to Israel, and says "it is not the will of your Father which is in heaven, that one of these little ones should perish" (Matthew 18:14), in the same kingdom setting. Jonah 4:11 speaks of persons "that cannot discern between their right hand and their left hand" in Nineveh. None of these says what happens to an infant at death, and none is read here as answering that question. They are reported as written, with the weight of the answer resting on David's comfort, on Paul's statements about law and accountability, and on God's character.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
2 Sa 12:23	"But now he is dead, wherefore should I fast? can I bring him back again? I shall go to him, but he shall not return to me."	"I shall go to him, but he shall not return to me."
Rom 4:15	"Because the law worketh wrath: for where no law is, there is no transgression."	"Where no law is, there is no transgression."
Rom 2:14–15	"For when the Gentiles, which have not the law, do by nature the things contained in the law, these, having not the law, are a law unto themselves: Which shew the work of the law written in their hearts, their conscience also bearing witness, and their thoughts the mean while accusing or else excusing one another;)"	Conscience bearing witness; a law unto themselves.

Gen 18:25	“That be far from thee to do after this manner, to slay the righteous with the wicked: and that the righteous should be as the wicked, that be far from thee: Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right?”	“Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right?”
Eph 1:13	“In whom ye also trusted, after that ye heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation: in whom also after that ye believed, ye were sealed with that holy Spirit of promise,”	Heard, believed, sealed.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** David says of the dead child “I shall go to him, but he shall not return to me” (2 Samuel 12:23). He had mourned while the child lived and stopped when it died, which is the answer he gives to his servants.
- **Stated:** Paul says “where no law is, there is no transgression” (Romans 4:15), and he writes of those without the law as “a law unto themselves,” their “conscience also bearing witness” (Romans 2:14–15). Accountability is tied to knowing.
- **Shown by the context:** the Lord’s dealings with a person are weighed by what that person has known: Abraham’s plea, “Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right?” (Genesis 18:25), is answered by the Lord’s patience, and the psalm describes him as “merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and plenteous in mercy” (Psalm 103:8), a general truth about his character.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul says the Body is formed by hearing and believing his gospel: “in whom also after that ye believed, ye were sealed with that holy Spirit of promise” (Ephesians 1:13). An infant has not believed, so death does not place him in the Body, and the Body is not the only company that is with God.
- **Shown by the context:** David’s servants feared to tell him the child was dead, but he rose, worshipped the Lord and ate (2 Samuel 12:20). His conduct shows he took the death as settled in God’s hands and did not despair.
- **Inferred:** that David’s “I shall go to him” means going to be with God, and that infants who die are received by God’s mercy. The text says David will go to the child and does not say where; the argument rests on David’s comfort, on Romans 4:15 and 2:14–15, and on God’s character.

The Other Readings

God saves all who die in infancy. John MacArthur (*Safe in the Arms of God*) holds that God receives infants who die by grace through Christ’s work, with 2 Samuel 12:23 as a main passage. This is close to the reading taken here, with the Body’s boundary stated. **Only the elect among them.** Loraine Boettner (*The Reformed Doctrine of Predestination*) held that all who die in infancy are elect. Wayne Grudem (*Systematic Theology*) is confident for the children of believers and leaves the rest to God’s mercy. They must explain why 2 Samuel 12 and Romans 4:15 give general grounds.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Received by grace	God receives all who die in infancy by mercy.	It must say infants are not Body members by death.
Only elect infants	Infants who die are those God elected.	It must show 2 Samuel 12:23 limits comfort to some.
Left unsaid	Scripture does not tell what becomes of infants.	David's comfort and Romans 4:15 point further.

What It Means for the Reader

The reader grieving an infant is told what David was told: the child is with God. The assurance rests on God's justice and mercy and not on a rite or a decision the infant could not make. Where the text is silent, the answer is not to guess against his character. The passage does not state a doctrine of an age of accountability, and it does not say where David expected to go. It records a father's comfort, and the argument adds only what the wider text and God's character bear. Where Scripture is silent, the reader is asked to leave the matter in God's hands and not to make up what it does not say.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 31, The Judgments of Scripture. **Companions:** 2 Samuel; Romans.

10. What Is the Conscience? Romans 2:15

THE ANSWER

The conscience is the inward moral witness God put in every person. Paul says it bears witness, "their thoughts the mean while accusing or else excusing one another." It is not infallible: some have a weak conscience that is easily wounded and "defiled." It must be shaped by Scripture, especially Paul's doctrine, and Paul allows believers to be "fully persuaded in his own mind" in matters of conscience. A strong conscience is formed by truth, as those "who by reason of use have their senses exercised to discern both good and evil," a general principle. The conscience does not save but shows a person's moral accountability: God will judge "the secrets of men by Jesus Christ according to my gospel." The Spirit uses Scripture to renew the mind and refine the conscience. It belongs to every human, as God's moral design for all.

Where the Verses Stand

Romans 2 speaks of Gentiles who do not have the law and yet do by nature what the law requires, showing "the work of the law written in their hearts," with their conscience bearing witness. Paul then names the day of judgment. In 1 Corinthians 8 he speaks of the weak conscience wounded by food offered to idols, and in Romans 14 of being persuaded in one's own mind.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Rom 2:15	"Which shew the work of the law written in their hearts, their conscience also bearing witness, and their thoughts the mean while accusing or else excusing one another;)"	Conscience bearing witness; thoughts accusing or excusing.
Rom 2:16	"In the day when God shall judge the secrets of men by Jesus Christ according to my gospel."	God will judge the secrets of men.
1 Co 8:7	"Howbeit there is not in every man that knowledge: for some with conscience of the idol unto this hour eat it as a thing offered unto an idol; and their conscience being weak is defiled."	Some have not the knowledge; weak conscience defiled.
1 Co 8:12	"But when ye sin so against the brethren, and wound their weak conscience, ye sin against Christ."	To wound a weak conscience is to sin against Christ.
Rom 14:5	"One man esteemeth one day above another: another esteemeth every day alike. Let every man be fully persuaded in his own mind."	"Let every man be fully persuaded in his own mind."

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Paul says the Gentiles show "the work of the law written in their hearts, their conscience also bearing witness, and their thoughts the mean while accusing or else excusing one another" (Romans 2:15). The conscience is a witness within.
- **Stated:** he says some believers have a conscience that is weak and can be defiled and wounded (1 Corinthians 8:7, 12). The conscience can be wrong or misinformed.

- **Shown by the context:** Paul puts the conscience under God's judgment, not above it: "In the day when God shall judge the secrets of men by Jesus Christ according to my gospel" (Romans 2:16). It bears witness; it does not decide.
- **Shown by the context:** where the Spirit works on the mind, the result is transformation by renewing the mind (Romans 12:2), which the weak and strong believer need alike. Hebrews 5:14 states the principle that sense is exercised by use to discern good and evil, and is used here as a general truth.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul calls himself to account before God and men: "herein do I exercise myself, to have always a conscience void of offence toward God, and toward men" (Acts 24:16). The conscience is something to be kept clear by attention, not merely a feeling to be obeyed.
- **Inferred:** that the conscience is a universal, God-given faculty, fallible and in need of Scripture to inform it. Paul's words about the Gentiles and about weak believers support both halves; the argument joins them.

The Other Readings

The voice of God. C. S. Lewis (*Mere Christianity*) takes the moral law within as the clue that a moral lawgiver stands behind the universe. This fits Paul's picture of a witness within and must explain why Paul treats the conscience as fallible. **A self-judging function.** C. A. Pierce (*Conscience in the New Testament*) describes the conscience in Paul as a retrospective, self-judging pain over past acts, and Robert Jewett (*Paul's Anthropological Terms*) as an autonomous function that is disabled when it is violated. The reading taken here rests the point that the conscience must be informed on Paul's own texts.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
An infallible inner voice	The conscience speaks for God.	Paul says it can be weak and defiled.
A trained faculty	It reflects what a person has learned.	Paul also says it is God's witness in all people.
Conscience as Savior	Following it earns acceptance.	It reveals accountability; Romans 2:16.

What It Means for the Reader

The reader is told to take the conscience seriously, because God put it there, and not to trust it blindly, because it can be weak or wrong. It is to be informed by Scripture and renewed, and it is to be respected in a brother: to wound a weak conscience is to sin against Christ. The passage does not say that every person's conscience agrees, and it does not set the conscience above Scripture. It describes a witness that accuses and excuses, and it leaves the reader to bring that witness to the word of God.

Related Reading

Companions: Romans; 1 Corinthians.

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